

attention for more reasons than one.

Yuki Tsunoda (**below**), who had been overlooked for the coveted promotion from the sister team Racing Bulls, had finally landed the Red Bull seat. Liam Lawson's lacklustre performances in just two races led to his departure, paving the way for his former RB teammate.

It was a dream-come-true moment for Tsunoda, as his race weekend debut with Red Bull was in front of his home crowd.

While the Japanese driver's abilities and talent were never in doubt, the conversation in the paddock was about whether Lawson had been given enough time to prove his worth. The full-season rookie was judged based on performances on two unfamiliar tracks, especially in a car that carried a dark cloud over it.

Now increasingly referred to as the 'second seat curse', Lawson had become the fifth victim after being given only two attempts. Such has been the case with Red Bull, which has remained cut-throat when it comes to finding the right driver to play second fiddle to Verstappen.

So, back in 13th and 14th on the starting grid, a two-way tussle between Lawson and Tsunoda was on the cards.

A damp squib

With showers early in the morning ahead of the race, it seemed like another dramatic affair was waiting to happen. The opening lap saw front-runners Verstappen and Norris point their cars towards each other, ready to put their elbows out heading into turn one.

As the lights went out, the pole-sitter cut off his McLaren rival perfectly, setting the tone for the rest of an error-free race. If there's one thing Verstappen excels at, it's leading from start to finish.

Behind the front three, Ferrari's Charles Leclerc held on to fourth, keeping the Mercedes pair of George Russell and Kimi Antonelli at bay. Russell had been consistently quick throughout the weekend,

while the young Antonelli continued to impress.

The 18-year-old had a shot at becoming the youngest-ever race winner but settled for the title of youngest race leader. Meanwhile, Tsunoda needed only a few laps to pass Lawson, completing a significant single-place 'swap'.

But apart from a few scattered overtakes, the event was labelled 'boring' by the drivers themselves. The narrow layout and slim overtaking opportunities left little room for excitement — though mistakes could still prove costly.

Nevertheless, the race heated up in the closing stages, with Norris and Piastri trying to chase down leader Verstappen. The Australian driver Piastri, coming off a win in China, even urged his team to let him pass his teammate in pursuit of victory.

Verstappen could see his rivals closing in, but holding them off was critical — a task he executed with ease. With the trophy in hand and a commanding victory secured, he ensured the battle for the Drivers' Championship is now wide open.



Catch him if you can: If there's one thing Verstappen excels at, it's leading from start to finish. That's exactly what he did at Suzuka. PICS: GETTY IMAGES

